

Mobility and Accessibility

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The fields of city and regional planning, civil and transportation engineering, and geography are all concerned with how humans use space and how they move from place to place. Each field – and each scholar within each field – has its own set of normative positions, recognized or unrecognized, about how the built environment should be structured and what role their discipline has in impacting this environment. In discussing these positions, a common vocabulary seems to arise: how do practitioners design a transportation system where people have high *mobility* and can easily *access* their needs? These terms, *mobility* and *accessibility*, find their way, undefined, into a huge diversity of research or policy questions that seem to be studying entirely different things. *How is the state Department of Transportation addressing impedance to mobility? How does increased women's mobility affect household labor dynamics? How is the planning department ensuring accessibility of public transportation to all people?* As one recognizes the differences in subjects in these questions, the terms begin to separate – geographers and engineers both implicitly assume mobility is good for people, but when engineers talk about mobility, they end up talking about vehicle speeds and never mentioning borders and visas. Meanwhile, contemporary planning scholars are calling for an “accessibility turn” in their field, de-emphasizing mobility. What emerges is a distinct understanding of these concepts across fields, with distinctive modes of measurement and description, and distinct normative positions. While each of these fields may state that the goal of their work is to improve people's lives, the definitions and attitudes about *mobility* and *accessibility* turn out to be central to how their work is enacted.

My interest in these terms lies in the policy implications of their use. In US transportation policy, “[mobility] metrics are not simply after-the-fact assessments but are also used proactively to guide policy toward transportation investment and land-use regulation.” (Levine et al., 2019, p. 3). *Mobility itself* is a strategic goal of the US Department of Transportation, and “trends in vehicle travel [are] an indicator of progress towards this goal” (Handy, 2002, p. 1). As Farrington (2007) argues, “there is a direct link between conceptual understanding and the implementation of derived policies” (p. 320). I am interested in how normative stances are justified and turn into policy prescriptions, because my political position is that social inclusion and access to needs should be achievable for any person, without ownership of a car. To work towards this goal, I need to speak the language of the people who make decisions about whether to build new roads, subsidize car infrastructure, and make alternative modes of transportation less safe and viable. At the same time, I would like to be able to ground my arguments in the language of human rights and recognize the importance of understanding the “underpinnings, experiences or representation of transport and travel” (Shaw and Hesse 2010, p. 309). I do not aim to reconcile the language used by different fields, or facilitate a one-to-one translation: just to navigate smoothly between these overlapping concepts, pulling from different literatures as needed.

In conversational language, mobility is the “ability to move freely,” describing, for example, the range of motion of a human knee. Some definitions don't expand much beyond this, but turn a focus to mobility as freedom of movement between distinct spaces: “In the context of transportation planning, mobility has been defined as the potential for movement, the ability to get from one place to another.” (Handy, 2002, p. 3) Other definitions “denote potential movement or a capacity to become mobile,” speak to “a certain level of energy and dynamism,”

or even attempt to encapsulate “the fragile entanglement of physical movement, the socially shared meanings ascribed to such movement, and the experienced and embodied practice of movement” (Kwan and Schwanen, 2006, p 244, citing Smith [1943], Sauer [1941], and Cresswell [2006]). In the planning literature, *accessibility* comes up as a natural pair to *mobility*, while in geography and engineering, mobility often stands alone. *Accessibility* has its own set of definitions: conversationally, it is the ease of use or access to something. More concretely, it is the “ability of people to reach and take part in activities normal for that society” (Farrington 2007, following Nutley 1998 and Church et al. 2000). More abstractly, it is the “potential of opportunities for interaction” (Hansen 1959, p73).

A characteristic of people or of their environment?

Across the above definitions, a distinction can be made – are “mobility” and “accessibility” characteristics held by people, or by the environments through which they are attempting to move? The intuitive understanding of mobility centers the person – whether someone has the ability to move. Planners and engineers, professionally concerned with the built environment, look at mobility as something that is influenced by that environment – for people to move faster along a road, the road must be built for faster speeds. Accessibility too can be read through both lenses: it succeeds or fails both as a function of a person’s abilities and as a function of the physical environment one is attempting to access. Farrington (2007) brings in the intersection of views: “Accessibility is at least as much about people as places. A place is not just ‘more’ or ‘less’ accessible, but accessible relative to people in all their different circumstances: people experience more, or less, access to places.”

This piece will engage with both types of definitions – those that treat “mobility” as something a person can have, and those that treat “mobility” as a function of the built environment. The differences between these approaches do fall loosely along disciplinary lines – the geographic literature foregrounds the lived experiences of people, while transportation professionals are often first concerned with how to shape the built environment, as a means of shaping people’s experiences. Keeping both the person-first and place-first approach to understanding mobility and accessibility in mind is necessary to understand the multiple levers that might be available for improving mobility or access – providing different tools or opportunities to people, or changing the characteristics of their environment. The following sections trace the uses of the terms across disciplines.

Mobilities in practice

Two professional disciplines, city planning and civil engineering, have a transportation subdiscipline. Professionals in both disciplines are charged with maintaining and improving transportation systems. What does it mean to “improve” a transportation system? Answering this question requires taking a normative stance on the purpose of the system. For a project to be funded as part of a State Transportation Improvement Plan, “improvement” needs to be defined and measured. The metrics used by practitioners to assess their work and normative implications of those metrics determine the kinds of environments they attempt to build. In these disciplines, mobility is the “potential for movement, the ability to get from one place to another” (Handy, 2002, p. 3). Levine et al. (2019) discuss what this means in practice: mobility is increased via an increase in the total area that can be reached within a certain time, usually by increasing the

speed of passenger vehicles. In contrast, *accessibility* is improved by increasing the “value of destinations” that can be reached in a certain time, increasing the “potential for interaction,” or improving the “intensity of the possibility of interactions” (Levine et al. 2019, Handy 2002, Hansen 1959). Scholars who promote this measure point out that underlying the emphasis on mobility – that is, the ability to move (quickly) – is an inherent misunderstanding of why movement matters. Although some travel is done purely for the sake of travel, most travel is a derived demand, meaning that it is performed in order to achieve some other goal: usually, you travel to get to the grocery store because you need groceries, not because you had a desire to travel. The transportation system exists primarily to help people meet their other needs or desires, not because the transportation system is itself desired or valuable. Nonetheless, mobility – the ability to move – has been central to planning and engineering: and “the fundamental criterion for success [in transportation systems] has long been faster vehicle-operating speed” (Levine et al 2019, p. 2).

The centrality of this measure might just be tradition, or a lack of critical examination of the objectives of the transportation system by engineers, who are ultimately charged with the material construction of transportation infrastructure. In *Killed By A Traffic Engineer*, engineer Wes Marshall argues that engineering dogma has changed little in the past 100 years, and that surprisingly little research is behind the current standards in transportation engineering. The transportation engineering field (once known as “traffic engineering”) established standards in the mid-20th century in guidebooks like the Highway Capacity Manual (published by the National Academies’ Transportation Research Board) and the Policy on Geometric Design of Highways and Streets (published by the American Association of State Highway and Transportation Officials). While these standards are updated relatively frequently, Marshall argues that their objective is to maintain performance (measured by speed, volume, or “Level of Service”, a measure of how freely traffic can move) more than it is to ensure safety, sustainability, accessibility, or any other objective. In *Confessions of a Recovering Engineer*, Chuck Marohn (the titular recovering engineer) specifically notes this objective: “the embedded values of the engineering profession prioritize speed and volume in order to maximize mobility, with the belief that increasing mobility is the ultimate good provided by a transportation system” (Marohn, 2021, p. 18). In prioritizing this kind of mobility, engineers are acting out the explicit goals of government bodies concerned with transportation. In most US municipalities, there is a legal requirement to conduct a traffic impact assessment alongside new development, in which the “impact” is assessed via changes to Level of Service (a mobility measure) and a reduction of Level of Service is required to be mitigated by the developer. The Bureau of Transportation Statistics publishes data on time “lost” to traffic congestion, as compared to a mythical baseline where people can move at the highest possible speed allowed by the road from their origin to their destination (Bureau of Transportation Statistics, 2021). Fatality rates, nominally a measure of safety, are measured in terms of fatalities *per vehicle mile travelled* rather than per capita, meaning that the rates can go down if the miles travelled go up, not by any changes to the number of people dying on streets (NCDOT, n.d.). Underlying these requirements and metrics is an assumption that more mobility, defined by the ability to move quickly, is better for people. Within this legal and disciplinary framework promoting an engineer’s understanding of mobility, there seems to be relatively little appetite for change.¹

¹ The origins of the idea that the function of the transportation system in the US is to move cars quickly can be convincingly attributed to the advocacy of the automobile industry in the 1920s-1930s, in response to a sales dip in new automobile purchases in 1923-1924, which the automakers attributed to a saturation of the

“Mobilities” in social sciences

Within geography, a discipline with a less intimate relationship with policy, the term “mobility” lent its name to an emerging genre of academic research in the 2000s concerned with a more sweeping set of questions associated with movement. According to Mei-Po Kwan and Tim Schwanen, editors of a special issue in *Annals of the American Association of Geographers* on “Geographies of Mobility,” the “mobilities turn” in the social sciences was made official by a 2006 paper by Mimi Sheller and John Urry in *Environment and Planning A: Economy and Space*. This paper argued that social sciences until this point had been “a-mobile,” not concerned with the movement of people both in their daily lives and in longer-sweeping movements across the world. Now, they argued, was the time to turn attention to movement. Sheller and Urry do not attempt to turn the “mobilities paradigm” into a single theory of everything - they describe it as “a set of questions, theories, and methodologies rather than a totalising or reductive description of the contemporary world” (p. 210), and are interested in the specific infrastructures that determine mobilities in different contexts, as well as the power relationships that determine differential access to mobility. The purpose of the “new mobilities” work is to pay explicit attention to movement to better explain and describe a world they no longer think can be fully explained with “sedentarist” explanations, mirroring a preoccupation with the discourses of globalization defining this period in academia:

Thus the new paradigm attempts to account for not only the quickening of liquidity within some realms but also the concomitant patterns of concentration that create zones of connectivity, centrality, and empowerment in some cases, and of disconnection, social exclusion, and inaudibility in other cases (Graham and Marvin 2001). (Sheller and Urry, 2006, p. 210).

Contemporaneously with this paper, Tim Cresswell published a book-length project - *On the move: mobility in the modern Western world*, seeking also to turn a specific emphasis onto movement. Cresswell was unsatisfied by existing transportation research, treating it as the study of movement *without studying its meaning*. Kwan and Schwanen cite additional scholars making a similar distinction: “mobility is bifurcated between an objective, primary realm of brute fact movement - and a further reality of secondary qualities and human “additions” - meaning, sensation, perception, feeling, and so forth” (Kwan and Schwanen, 2016, p. 245). These conceptualizations of mobility set up a distinction, real or imagined, between transportation research and “mobilities research.”

automobile market and public distaste for the “dangerous intruders” on their streets. This paper isn’t meant to review this history, but it’s an important explanatory factor – early “safety” and engineering regulations were captured by experts hired by the Studebaker Corporation, who stood up the first traffic research institute – the Erskine Bureau for Street Traffic Research – to redefine the perceived problems of traffic safety and congestion into a problem formulation that would be compatible with the continued sale of cars. An excellent review of this history can be found in Dr. Peter Norton’s dissertation-turned-book *Fighting Traffic: The Dawn of the Motor Age in the American City* (2008). While I haven’t traced the continued influence of the automobile lobby on current policymaking and standard-setting, I’d be surprised if that influence had completely disappeared from transportation policy!

Transportation geography emerged as a recognized subfield of geography in the 1950s, first showing up as a named AAG subfield in 1954 (Taaffe and Gauthier, 1994). From its early years, transportation geography was associated with the “quantitative revolution” in geography. The rise of modeling as a method in geography was incubated in early transportation models, and modeling and spatial analysis were central to transportation geography in the 1950s-1970s. While Taaffe and Gauthier (1994) argue that transportation was a concern of geographers throughout the 20th century, they also note that the emergence of the recognized subfield coinciding with the “quantitative revolution” in geography gave transportation geography a positivist reputation. They accept that most of the work of transport geographers was explicitly spatial, but reject the premise that transportation geography was a “positivist field,” noting the plurality of approaches and questions within the discipline, and that few “transport geographers...could be classified as true believers in the ultimate discovery of a definitive set of mega-theories.” (Taaffe and Gauthier, 1994, p. 159) Instead, transportation geographers were often engaged in context-specific normative research, such as designing “optimal” air traffic routes (as a separate project from building *explanatory* models of transportation, which some transportation geographers nonetheless did). They also note a trend in transportation geography to reject the “economically rational person” in behavioral economics, instead turning to “psychological, social, cultural, and historical” bases on which to rest their understanding of people’s travel behavior (Taaffe and Gauthier, 1994, p.161).

The fact that the “mobilities paradigm” was thought of as a turn towards something new in the social sciences rather than an evolution of existing research on how people move, despite the wide diversity of research in transportation geography, is explained by Shaw and Hesse in their review of the (dis)connections between transport geography and ‘mobilities’ research: “the intellectual journeys of these approaches to the study of movement have followed generally different trajectories on account of being taken by different types of academic, interested in different aspects of movement and speaking different kinds of language” (Shaw and Hesse, 2010, p. 305). What, then, are the “new mobilities” scholars talking about when they talk about “mobility”? Kwan and Schwanen reference the intellectual history of the term. In the second half of the 20th century, “the term mobility was used predominantly to denote residential movements by human individuals and households. Even in that period, however, the term had multiple uses: It was used in relation to individuals' daily and weekly tripmaking (Wheeler 1972), the upward social mobility of individuals (Breese 1963), the ongoing movements of cattle and herders (Kollmorgen 1969), and even in Foucauldian fashion as a synonym for energy and force (Sack 1976).” (Kwan and Schwanen, 2016, p244). In more contemporary research, Shaw and Hesse summarize the definition of mobility as “not just a means of providing access to workplaces and amenities, but more broadly as a constitutive framework for modern society, providing opportunities and constraints...over time and across space” (p306). Across these geographers’ reviews of mobility, we see a bias towards larger movements (as measured in physical distance travelled) as the object of mobilities research: Sheller and Urry open with imagery of “asylum seekers, international students, terrorists, members of diasporas, holidaymakers, business people, sports stars, refugees, backpackers, commuters, the early retired, young mobile professionals, prostitutes, armed forces [filling the] world's airports, buses, ships, and trains” (Sheller and Urry, 2006, p. 207). Nonetheless, these greatest-hits lists make a hat tip to shorter-distance movements, saying that these global movements must be “brought together with more ‘local’ concerns about everyday transportation” (Sheller and Urry, 2006, p. 212). In addition to the broad diversity of topics contained in “mobilities studies,” mobilities scholars have focused on the implications of a

mobilities paradigm to all of geography, not just the idea of mobility on its own. Sheller and Urry explain why geographers must move beyond “a-mobile” social sciences: “all places are tied into at least thin networks of connections that stretch beyond each such place and mean that nowhere can be an ‘island’” (Sheller and Urry, 2006, p. 209). In this literature, however, a normative position does not seem to arise around whether mobility in and of itself is a good, or at least a necessary precondition for some other societal good. While this research is no longer “a-mobile,” it may be “a-political,” at least in lacking a politics of its own. This is an observation drawn not just from my (admittedly shallow) reading of the literature, but also named by scholars within geography: “Apparently absent from the new mobilities discourse embraced by Urry and others is a normative dimension, in contrast to the accessibility narrative and indeed many of the current discourses of transport and human geography.” (Farrington, 2007, p. 327). This paper will return to the “accessibility narrative” referenced here by Farrington and its potential for a political position.

Interestingly, only Sheller and Urry reference Doreen Massey in their reviews (and even there she is not reference as a *participant* in the “mobilities turn,” but as the theorist behind the idea of “power geometries”), despite her clear attention to movement and even explicit usage of the term “mobility” in her analysis of power in flows. In *Space, Place, and Gender*, when discussing the difference between movements of social groups with different degrees of power, she refers to this phenomenon as “differentiated mobility,” where “some are more in charge of it than others” (Massey, 1996 p. 149). She proceeds directly to an analysis that implies the need for a normative position of the kind Farrington laments as missing:

If time-space compression can be imagined in that more socially formed, socially evaluative and differentiated way, then there may be here the possibility of developing a politics of mobility and access. For it does seem that mobility, and control over mobility, both reflects and reinforces power. It is not simply a question of unequal distribution, that some people move more than others, and that some have more control than others. It is that the mobility and control of some groups can actively weaken other people. Differential mobility can weaken the leverage of the already weak. The time-space compression of some groups can undermine the power of others.

... every time someone uses a car, and thereby increases their personal mobility, they reduce both the social rationale and the financial viability of the public transport system — and thereby also potentially reduce the mobility of those who rely on that system. Every time you drive to that out-of-town shopping centre you contribute to the rising prices, even hasten the demise, of the corner shop. And the ‘time-space compression’ which is involved in producing and reproducing the daily lives of the comfortably-off in First World societies — not just their own travel but the resources they draw on, from all over the world, to feed their lives — may entail environmental consequences, or hit constraints, which will limit the lives of others before their own. We need to ask, in other words, whether our relative mobility and power over mobility and communication entrenches the spatial imprisonment of other groups. (Massey, 1996, p. 150)

Massey provides some provocation to consider whether “more mobility” is an inherent good: she recognizes that mobility for some might decrease mobility for others, and speaks to the negative consequences (e.g. environmental, economic) that might result from more mobility.

This provocation has been taken up in the planning discipline, with an explicit attention to human flourishing and a critical re-examination of the inherent value of “mobility”.

Accessibility is more valuable than mobility for guiding policy

An *accessibility turn* in planning has been a response to the failures of a mobility-oriented normative framework, trickling from policy to implementation, to meet people’s needs. Whereas a mobility-oriented framework asks “can people move around with relative ease?”, an accessibility-oriented framework asks “do people have access to the activities that they need or want to participate in?” (Handy, 2002, p. 4). Accessibility, as it is understood and pursued in practice, is a more powerful goal than mobility in terms of its ability to improve lives. Most movement that is facilitated by the US transportation system is performed in order to meet a need, not because that movement is itself needed. Of course, an after-dinner walk or a bike ride in the park may be meeting a human desire for movement directly, not by facilitating access to a destination. However, a miniscule fraction of the 3.1 trillion miles travelled annually by vehicles on US roadways are travel for travel’s sake – these are miles travelled to get to destinations to fulfill human desires or needs. In their 2019 book, *From Mobility to Accessibility: Transforming Urban Transportation and Land-Use Planning*, authors Levine, Grengs, and Merlin provide a metaphor to describe the futility of optimizing transportation systems by optimizing the mobility they provide, saying that this is equivalent to assessing farmer’s productivity by measuring and reporting the amount of fertilizer they use, rather than the amount of crops they produce – and that this type of evaluation would inevitably lead to bad policy-making (Levine *et al.*, 2019). Similarly, transportation systems should not be evaluated by how many miles of travel they facilitate, but by how well they serve people’s access needs.

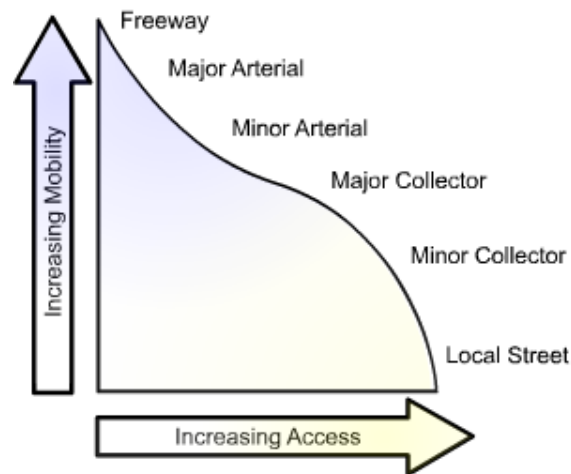
Similarly, Farrington (2007) points out the weakness of a focus on mobility for policymakers concerned with social inclusion:

“It is not necessarily lack of mobility that those who experience constrained access will experience, though of course this is often a component. A wider and, in terms of human good, more important, deprivation than lack of mobility is experienced by those with constrained access, which amounts to a narrower range of life opportunities and thus, we expect, of life chances.” (Farrington, 2007, p.322).

An accessibility framework is concerned with the “ability of people *to engage with life opportunities*...far more than ‘the ability to travel to a shop’, [making] accessibility central in a schema of social inclusion and social justice.” (Farrington, 2007, p. 322; emphasis in original). By explicitly focusing on the provision of access to life opportunities, an accessibility framework explicitly takes on human flourishing as its goal.

In contrast, improving mobility directly does not inevitably lead to desired outcomes, and “good mobility is neither a sufficient nor a necessary condition for good accessibility” (Handy, 2002, p. 4). When considering levels of mobility/accessibility as characteristics of the built environment, improving mobility can decrease access: roadways designed for higher speed must have fewer entry points to maintain those high speeds (merging into traffic slows down travel, so engineers design higher-speed roads with fewer intersections and points of conflict), limiting the number of destinations one can actually access from that road. This trade-off in built environment characteristics is institutionalized wisdom within transportation practice. Figure 1

shows a conceptual model for roadway classification into different “functional classes” (Federal Highway Administration, n.d.)



In this framework, when considering the “mobility” or “accessibility” of a piece of transportation infrastructure, the terms are understood in opposition to one another. As a characteristic of the *environment*, the ability to access destinations is understood to be an impedance to the ability to move.

When considering mobility as an ability held by people, mobility does not naturally oppose accessibility – but it does not necessarily promote accessibility, either. Improving mobility for some often impedes access for others, as noted by Massey. For example, construction of urban freeways destroyed primarily Black neighborhoods in cities across the United States and divided the remaining neighborhoods such that it was no longer possible to walk from one side to another (Sullivan, 2021). Even smaller roadways impede access for nondriving populations, separating children from schools that are theoretically within walking distance but not safe to reach on foot, or leaving elderly people isolated in homes they can no longer leave without being driven. Given this distinction, some planning scholars have suggested turning their focus towards accessibility, working toward mobility only when it supports increased accessibility and not as an end to itself. In transportation planning, mobility-focused approaches might focus on building new roads or using technological improvements like ramp metering to improve efficiency of roadways, while accessibility-focused planning might promote infill development, transit-oriented development, or street connectivity to improve the quality of destinations that can be accessed or diversify ways to access these destinations (Handy, 2002).

Levine *et al.* suggest that accessibility is worth valuing and pursuing as its own objective good, not just a means to achieve environmental benefits or improvements to public health (Levine *et al.*, 2019). They argue for the *potential* of an accessibility-focused approach to planning to more effectively meet people’s needs by broadening the range of approaches to improve transportation outcomes (beyond building new roads or widening existing ones), but they are not yet optimistic about the ubiquity of the “accessibility turn” in their discipline. They characterize the view “that accessibility promotion is inherently valuable as a normative goal rather than just a predictive variable” as “controversial,” saying that “social scientists in general are more comfortable with analysis and prediction than with prescription, and scholars have been

more inclined to use measured accessibility as a predictive variable...than to transform planning practice” (Levine et al 2019, p 13). As a result of this unease with normativity, they state that accessibility-based approaches haven’t left the hands of researchers to be widely applied.

Bringing normative positions to theory and practice

Practitioners, or at least academics writing about planning practice, have begun to describe the practical implications of assumptions about the inherent value of “mobility” or “accessibility.” The focus of these fields is admittedly narrow – they ask questions about how people travel domestically over relatively short distances in their daily life, not the whole breadth of questions asked by “new mobilities” geographers focused on migration, embodied experiences, or globalization. Nonetheless, these supposedly positivist disciplines, lacking engagement with the “meaning, sensation, perception, feeling” associated with different experiences of mobility (Kwan and Schwanen, 2016, p. 245), have managed to engage with and describe the power held by terminology. They have described the implications for the material world of valuing “mobility” as an inherent good, and pointed out the gaps left behind when the purpose of movement isn’t incorporated into one’s analysis. Kwan and Schwanen point out that the apparent distinction between those studying the perceptual dimensions of movement with those focused on “objective” facts of movement does not make these two strands of research, in actuality, separate. They note that these two approaches are simply “creating different abstractions...through their methodological practice” that could still be bridged through collaboration (Kwan and Schwanen, 2016, p. 245). Shaw and Hesse also suggest that there something to be gained by bridging the distance between ‘traditional’ transportation geography and the ‘new mobilities paradigm,’ to the benefit of both disciplines. They see the value in transportation geographers developing “a more sophisticated appreciation of movement” – the aforementioned second layer of meanings and feelings – but also suggest that mobilities scholars develop a “stronger articulation of the case as to why [this sophisticated appreciation] is important within and beyond academic human geography.” (Shaw and Hesse, 2010, p. 305). My interest in the material experiences of transportation, and the health, independence, safety, and environmental impacts of transportation, makes me sympathetic to the importance of a clear articulation of the value of this type of academic work for setting normative policy recommendations. In fact, Shaw and Hesse put it even more bluntly:

“mobilities geographers not engaging with policy debates will diminish the likelihood of their work having an impact beyond immediate academic circles. While those in mobilities are frequently keen to foreground the ‘intangible and ephemeral, the meanings that accrue in the context of the journey itself ... the sensory, kinaesthetic and symbolic aspects ... [and] affective factors’ (Spinney 2009, 821) in order to gain more realistic understandings of people’s mobility, we might well ask, so what?” (Shaw and Hesse, 2010, p309)

The answer to “so what” lies in whether the answers you find can be communicated to someone with the power to materially affect the experience of transportation – whether that’s the traveler themselves, the city’s public works department, or a federal agency. In my own research, I’m interested both in quantitatively describing the ability of children to access the destinations of their daily life, and the experiential impacts of the mode of transit taken (do they feel more

connected to their community when they walk to school? Does their father grabbing their hand at the crosswalk make them feel tense and unsafe?). It's important to me, however, that when I describe children's experiences of mobility and accessibility, I do not attempt to take an objective and detached position. Following Olson and Sayer (2009), I instead mean to justify a set of values around what I believe children's travel experiences could and should look like, and discuss the policy interventions that could achieve those outcomes.

Perhaps such bold normative stances will be more likely if scholars collaborate across historical divisions – mobilities scholars and transportation geographers, planners and engineers, academics and practitioners. Whether this happens in collaboration or within a single discipline, however, I suggest that starting from a clear definition of the concept being studied or described – and unearthing whether that definition carries with it value judgements – will allow researchers to center normative positions from the inception of their research.

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